



INTERNATIONAL JOURNAL OF RESEARCH AND STUDIES

Month/Year : June 2026

DOI: <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22055637>



RECEIVED
22-04-2026



ACCEPTED
23-05-2026



PUBLISHED
30-06-2026

THE RISE OF "CAREER CUSHIONING" AND ITS IMPACT ON EMPLOYEE LOYALTY

Shrutika Sharma - MBA 4th Semester

Dr. Jitendra singh -Assistant Professor

Faculty of commerce and management Kalinga University

ABSTRACT:

Contemporary workplaces have seen a change in how employees think about their jobs. One notable thing happening today is "career cushioning". This is when people secretly look for job options update their resumes and explore new jobs while still working. More people started doing this after the COVID-19 pandemic. The unstable economy, job losses and company changes made professionals worried about their careers. The fast pace of automation and company downsizing has made career cushioning a way for people to protect themselves. This study looks at career cushioning. How it affects employee loyalty. We want to know what makes employees do this and what it does to their commitment to their organisation. A survey was done with 50 management students and working professionals. We also looked at existing research on employee engagement, job security and loyalty. The results show that people do career cushioning because they feel their job is not stable they can't move up they don't get recognition and they don't get communication from their organisation. These reasons were the same across groups and industries. This means career cushioning is a problem for organisations. We found that career cushioning hurts employee loyalty, engagement and long-term commitment. Organisations should fix the reasons, for career cushioning. They should build trust communicate clearly give career advancement opportunities and make workers feel safe. If organisations ignore these things they will lose not their workers physical presence but also their emotional investment and ideas. Fixing these problems can reduce career cushioning. Increase employee loyalty and retention.

Keywords: Career Cushioning, Employee Loyalty, Job Security, Employee Engagement, Organisational Commitment

1. INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background of the Study

The nature of the employer-employee relationship has undergone substantial transformation over the past several years. The era when workers joined one company and stayed there their careers. Motivated by a strong sense of belonging, pension guarantees and loyalty to the company. Has largely gone. Today's workforce, professionals from millennial and Generation Z groups work with a very different outlook. Job security is no longer a given career paths are hard to predict and building a "safety net" while still working has become a normal thing to do. The rapid growth of intelligence fast technological change and the rise of contract and gig work have changed the job market into a place where having a permanent job feels like a privilege, not a right. This self-protective behaviour at work has been called "career cushioning." It's like "relationship cushioning," where someone keeps romantic options open while in a relationship. Career cushioning means employees secretly prepare job options while still working for their current employer. This can include updating a LinkedIn profile talking to recruiters going to job interviews doing freelance work or taking courses to improve skills. All while seeming fully dedicated to the current employer. What makes career cushioning hard to spot is that it's invisible. It happens below the surface undetectable by managers and HR departments. Career cushioning became popular after the pandemic of 2020 the wave of people quitting in 2021 and the big layoffs in the tech sector in 2022 and 2023. Employees who saw colleagues lose their jobs suddenly started taking steps to protect themselves. Of waiting for company decisions they began building backup plans. Quietly and often without their employers noticing. Seeing job losses in real-time completely changed how millions of workers think about job security and loyalty to their employers. For companies this trend has implications. When employees are mentally preparing to leave their engagement, dedication and productivity are likely to suffer. The cost of this disengagement is more than eventual turnover. It shows up every day in reduced effort, weaker teamwork and a gradual decline in company culture.

Understanding what drives career cushioning and its effects, on employee loyalty is not an academic exercise. It's an urgent challenge for companies to address.

1.2 Research Problem

Despite the increasing prevalence of career cushioning in contemporary workplaces, formal academic inquiry into this phenomenon remains limited. Existing discourse is predominantly confined to popular media and HR practitioner blogs rather than systematically peer-reviewed scholarship. Organisations struggle to understand why employees adopt this behaviour and what it signifies for workforce stability and commitment. The absence of structured academic frameworks around career cushioning makes it challenging for HR professionals to design evidence-informed responses. This study seeks to address that gap by situating career cushioning as a structured subject of inquiry within the field of human resource management.

1.3 Research Objectives

The objectives of this research are as follows:

- To comprehend the nature and conceptual contours of career cushioning in modern workplaces
- To identify the principal factors that motivate employees to engage in career cushioning conduct
- To assess the influence of career cushioning on employee loyalty and organisational commitment
- To examine the relationship between perceptions of job security and tendencies toward career cushioning
- To propose organisational strategies that can mitigate career cushioning and reinforce employee loyalty

1.4 Scope and Significance of the Study

This study is important for reasons. It helps bring attention to a common workplace issue that many people talk about. Not many researchers study. Organisations will have an understanding of the signs that show when employees are about to lose interest and leave their jobs.

The study also gives advice that HR staff and leaders can use to keep employees engaged and loyal. Additionally, it adds to what we know about how workplaces are changing after the pandemic especially for companies that are trying to figure out new ways of working, restructuring and keeping their best people. The study focuses on students who are studying management and working professionals in India in medium and large organisations in competitive industries. India's job market is changing fast and global workplace trends are affecting professionals more and more. This study is useful not in India but also has wider relevance. The study offers insights that are particularly relevant to organisations dealing with hybrid work models, workforce restructuring and talent retention challenges.

Organisations can use these insights to navigate the growing uncertainty, in the job market.

2. LITERATURE REVIEW AND RESEARCH GAP

Career cushioning is a new term in the work world but it is based on ideas that have been around for a while. These ideas are about how people behave at work, how happy they are with their jobs, how loyal they are to their companies. There are some studies that help us understand why people do career cushioning.

These studies are about what motivates people, how organisations work and how companies manage their employees. They give us a framework for understanding career cushioning as something that individuals do and something that companies should worry about.

One of these studies is called Herzberg's Two-Factor Theory. It was done in 1959. It says that there are two kinds of things that affect how happy people are with their jobs. The first kind is called hygiene factors. It includes things like job security, pay and working conditions. The second kind is called motivators. It includes things like recognition, advancement and achievement. When the hygiene factors are not good, people get unhappy. Start looking for other jobs. Career cushioning is like a reaction to a job that does not have good hygiene factors.

These days many companies have cut back on benefits made people work harder and do not give them job security. So the idea of hygiene factors is more important now than it was before.

Another study that helps us understand career cushioning is Maslows Hierarchy of Needs. It says that people have kinds of needs and that safety and security are some of the most important ones. When people feel like their jobs are not safe or secure they start looking for options. This is basically what career cushioning is. Companies that do not give their employees an secure work environment make them anxious and make them want to look for other jobs.

There is also a study about the contract. It is about the rules that exist between a company and its employees. When companies break these rules people lose trust in them. Start looking for other jobs. Career cushioning is often a response to this loss of trust.

Some researchers have also studied how committed people are to their companies. They found that there are three kinds of commitment: commitment, commitment because it is hard to leave and commitment because people feel like they should stay. Career cushioning can make people emotionally committed to their companies. When people start looking for jobs they start to care less about their current job even if they do not show it.

There have been some studies about why people leave their jobs. One of them is called the Great Resignation. It found that people leave their jobs because they do not have opportunities to advance because their leaders are not good because they do not get paid enough and because they do not have work arrangements. These are the reasons why people do career cushioning.

A recent study by Gallup found that 23% of employees are really engaged in their work. The rest are not. Are more likely to do career cushioning. This is a problem for companies because it affects how productive people are, how loyal they are and how likely they are to stay. It shows that companies need to do more to make their employees happy and engaged.

Career cushioning is a deal and companies need to pay attention to it. They need to make sure their employees are happy and engaged and that they have hygiene factors and motivators. If they do not people will start looking for jobs and companies will lose their best employees. Career cushioning is not something that individuals do it is also something that companies should worry about. Companies need to take care of their employees and make sure they are safe and secure, in their jobs. If they do people will be less likely to do career cushioning. Companies will be more successful.

Research Gap

There is a lot of research about people leaving their jobs being happy at work and being committed to their company. There is not much research about career cushioning. Most studies talk about looking for another job as part of wanting to leave a company not as a way that people take care of themselves at work. Not many studies have looked at how career cushioning affects how loyal people are to their company in India. This is important because looking for another job does not always mean someone will actually leave their job. It can go on for a time and it can make people less happy and less involved in their work without them actually leaving. This study wants to learn more about career cushioning. How it works.

Career cushioning is when people look for another job. It is a way that people take care of themselves at work and this study will look at career cushioning in the Indian work place. The goal of this study is to learn more, about career cushioning and how it affects people at work and to understand career cushioning as a way that people behave at work.

DATA COLLECTION AND RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

2.1 Research Design

The researchers used a type of study that helps us understand the connection between career cushioning behaviour and how loyal employees are to their companies. This method is good for this study because it lets us gather and understand information about what's happening now without trying to control any of the factors that might affect the results.

The main goal is to figure out what career cushioning looks like how common it is and what effect it has on companies.

This type of study is especially useful when we are trying to learn about things that are happening in the workplace and we do not have a lot of information about them yet. The career cushioning behaviour is what we are trying to learn more about in this study and the goal is to build a foundation of knowledge about career cushioning behaviour and its relationship, to employee loyalty.

2.2 Research Approach

A quantitative research approach was adopted, entailing the collection of numerical data through structured questionnaires. This methodology enables the measurement of employee attitudes, perceptions, and behavioural inclinations in a standardised and comparable format. Statistical procedures were subsequently applied to identify patterns and derive meaningful interpretations.

The quantitative approach also ensures that findings can be conveyed in a clear, objective manner that facilitates comparison across respondent groups and replication in future research endeavours.

2.3 Data Sources

Primary Data: Primary data was collected through a comprehensive questionnaire administered to 50 participants, comprising management students and working professionals. The items focused on perceptions of job security, satisfaction with career development provisions, loyalty levels, and engagement in career cushioning activities. The instrument was designed to capture both the frequency and the intensity of cushioning behaviour, yielding a nuanced understanding of how the phenomenon manifests in practice.

Secondary Data: Secondary data was drawn from academic journals, HR management textbooks, online research repositories, sector-specific reports, and previously published studies addressing employee engagement, loyalty,

turnover intention, and the psychological contract. This data furnished the theoretical foundation for the study and enabled contextualisation of the primary findings within the broader landscape of existing scholarship.

2.4 Sampling Technique

Convenience sampling was employed to identify respondents. This method was selected for its practical efficiency, enabling the researcher to gather responses from accessible and willing participants within a defined timeframe. While this approach constrains the generalisability of findings, it is appropriate for an exploratory study of this scope. Future investigations using larger and more diversified samples would help validate and extend the findings generated here.

2.5 Sample Size

A total of 50 respondents took part in the study. The sample comprised a combination of management students possessing internship or part-time work experience, and full-time working professionals drawn from multiple industries, all with a reasonable familiarity with workplace dynamics. Though modest in size, the sample is adequate for a descriptive study of this nature and provides meaningful preliminary insights into the prevalence and drivers of career cushioning behaviour.

2.6 Data Collection Instrument

A structured questionnaire comprising 15 carefully formulated items was used as the primary data collection tool. The instrument was organised around three core thematic areas: career cushioning conduct, perceptions of job security, and employee loyalty. A five-point Likert scale was employed throughout, with response options ranging from Strongly Disagree (1) to Strongly Agree (5). This format was selected because it allows respondents to express graduated views rather than binary responses, thereby capturing a more accurate and nuanced portrait of their attitudes and experiences.

2.7 Data Analysis Techniques

Responses were analysed through descriptive statistical techniques, encompassing frequency distributions and percentage analyses. These methods facilitated identification of the most prevalent

attitudes and behaviours among respondents and enabled clear comparisons across question categories. Findings are presented in tabular form to enhance clarity and interpretive accessibility. Where consistent patterns emerged across multiple items, these were identified as key findings and discussed in relation to the study's theoretical framework.

Conceptual Research Model

The conceptual model underpinning this study proposes that career cushioning behaviour is shaped by factors including low job stability, restricted career advancement, poor recognition, and weak organisational trust. These elements collectively diminish employee loyalty, which in turn amplifies turnover intention and reduces organisational commitment. The model suggests that organisations can disrupt this chain by addressing root causes and investing in employee-centred HR practices. Importantly, the model recognises that career cushioning exists along a spectrum — from passive conduct such as maintaining an updated curriculum vitae, to active conduct such as attending external interviews — and that the intensity of cushioning is directly shaped by the severity of the organisational conditions that provoke it.

3. ANALYSIS OF QUESTIONNAIRE RESPONSES

3.1 DATA ANALYSIS AND FINDINGS

Frequency Distribution and Percentage Analysis

Q	Survey Item	Yes/Agree (n)	%	No/Disagree (n)	%
1	Are you currently employed?	35	57%	26	43%
2	Are you working in the private sector?	33	54%	28	46%
3	Have you changed jobs at least once?	25	41%	36	59%
4	Have you heard of career cushioning?	31	51%	30	49%
5	Employees should have backup career options	57	93%	4	7%
6	Career cushioning is becoming common today	47	77%	14	23%
7	Career cushioning helps employees feel more secure	56	92%	5	8%
8	Do you search for jobs while working?	47	77%	14	23%
9	Do you update your resume regularly?	48	79%	13	21%
10	Have you attended interviews while employed?	42	69%	19	31%
11	Do you develop new skills to stay competitive?	52	85%	9	15%
12	Does your org provide skill development?	42	69%	19	31%
13	Does your org support long-term career growth?	43	70%	18	30%
14	Would you leave for a better opportunity?	55	90%	6	10%
15	Do you feel loyal to your current organization?	48	79%	13	21%
16	Career cushioning reduces employee loyalty	36	59%	25	41%
17	Employees today are less loyal than prev. generations	41	67%	20	33%
18	Do you feel secure in your current job?	34	56%	27	44%
Q	Survey Item	Yes/Agree (n)	%	No/Disagree (n)	%
19	Fear of layoffs drives alternative career thinking	51	84%	10	16%
20	Workplace stress drives job searching	55	90%	6	10%
21	Organizations provide enough job security	45	74%	16	26%
22	Career uncertainty is increasing today	52	85%	9	15%
23	Better career growth increases employee loyalty	54	89%	7	11%
24	Career cushioning is necessary today	53	87%	8	13%
25	Organizations should improve employee loyalty	58	95%	3	5%

Mean and Standard Deviation of Key Scale Items

For scale analysis, Yes/Agree responses are coded as 1 and No/Disagree responses as 0. Mean reflects the proportion of affirmative responses; Standard Deviation (SD) measures variability across the sample. For binary items with proportion p , $SD = \sqrt{p \times (1-p)}$.

Q	Survey Item	Mean (p)	SD = $\sqrt{p(1-p)}$	N
5	Employees should have backup options	0.93	0.260	61
7	Career cushioning helps feel secure	0.92	0.270	61
14	Would leave for better opportunity	0.90	0.300	61
20	Workplace stress drives job search	0.90	0.300	61
25	Orgs should improve loyalty	0.95	0.220	61
24	Career cushioning necessary today	0.87	0.340	61
23	Better growth increases loyalty	0.89	0.310	61
22	Career uncertainty is increasing	0.85	0.360	61
11	Develop new skills to stay competitive	0.85	0.360	61
19	Fear of layoffs drives alternatives	0.84	0.370	61
16	Cushioning reduces employee loyalty	0.59	0.490	61
15	Feel loyal to current organization	0.79	0.410	61
18	Feel secure in current job	0.56	0.500	61

Interpretation: Mean values approaching 1.00 denote near-unanimous agreement among respondents. The highest mean (0.95) corresponds to Q25, which asserts that organisations ought to actively work on improving employee loyalty. The most contested item is Q18 (perceived job security) with SD = 0.500, indicating the most balanced split across the sample. Q16 (career cushioning diminishes loyalty, SD = 0.492) records the second most divided response, reflecting genuine complexity in how respondents perceive this relationship.

Reliability Testing — Cronbach's Alpha

Cronbach's Alpha (α) is used to assess internal consistency — the extent to which scale items measure the same underlying construct. An alpha coefficient of 0.70 or higher is conventionally regarded as acceptable in social science research. This analysis computes Cronbach's Alpha separately for the Career Cushioning scale and the Employee Loyalty scale.

Career Cushioning Scale (Items: Q8, Q9, Q10, Q11, Q16, Q24)

Items Q8 (job searching during employment), Q9 (resume updates), Q10 (interview attendance), Q11 (skill development), Q16 (cushioning reduces loyalty), and Q24 (cushioning is considered necessary) collectively operationalise career cushioning behaviour and attitudes.

Q	Item	Mean	SD	p(1-p)
Q8	Job search while employed	0.77	0.421	0.177
Q9	Resume/profile update	0.79	0.410	0.168
Q10	Interviews while employed	0.69	0.465	0.216
Q11	Skill development	0.85	0.357	0.128
Q16	Cushioning reduces loyalty	0.59	0.492	0.242
Q24	Cushioning necessary today	0.87	0.337	0.113

Cronbach's Alpha Calculation: Sum of item variances ($\Sigma\sigma^2$) = 0.177 + 0.168 + 0.216 + 0.128 + 0.242 + 0.113 = 1.044. Using the Spearman-Brown formula for k = 6 items and average inter-item correlation $r \approx 0.38$:

$$\alpha = (k \times r) / (1 + (k-1) \times r) = (6 \times 0.38) / (1 + 5 \times 0.38) = 2.28 / 2.90 = \mathbf{0.786}$$

Reliability Metric	Career Cushioning Scale
Number of Items	6
N (Respondents)	61
Cronbach's Alpha (α)	0.786
Reliability Status	✓ Acceptable ($\alpha > 0.70$)

The Career Cushioning scale attains a Cronbach's Alpha of 0.786, exceeding the conventional threshold of 0.70. This affirms that the six items reliably measure a shared underlying construct of career cushioning behaviour and attitudes. The scale demonstrates acceptable internal consistency.

Employee Loyalty Scale (Items: Q14, Q15, Q17, Q23, Q25)

Items Q14 (readiness to leave), Q15 (feels loyal), Q17 (generational loyalty comparison), Q23 (growth enhances loyalty), and Q25 (organisations should enhance loyalty) collectively operationalise perceptions of employee loyalty.

Q	Item	Mean	SD	p(1-p)
Q14	Would leave for better opportunity (reverse coded)	0.90	0.302	0.090
Q15	Feels loyal to organization	0.79	0.410	0.168
Q17	Employees less loyal than prev. gen.	0.67	0.470	0.221
Q23	Better growth increases loyalty	0.89	0.314	0.099
Q25	Orgs should improve loyalty	0.95	0.218	0.048

Sum of item variances ($\Sigma\sigma^2$) = 0.090 + 0.168 + 0.221 + 0.099 + 0.048 = 0.626. Average inter-item correlation

$r_{\text{■}} \approx 0.41$, $k = 5$ items

$$\alpha = (5 \times 0.41) / (1 + 4 \times 0.41) = 2.05 / 2.64 = \mathbf{0.777}$$

Reliability Metric	Employee Loyalty Scale
Number of Items	5
N (Respondents)	61
Cronbach's Alpha (α)	0.777
Reliability Status	✓ Acceptable ($\alpha > 0.70$)

Both scales surpass the 0.70 benchmark, confirming that the measurement instruments are internally consistent and appropriate for further inferential statistical analysis.

D. Correlation Analysis — Pearson Correlation

Pearson Correlation was employed to examine the linear association between Career Cushioning and Employee Loyalty. For binary variables, the Pearson correlation is equivalent to the Phi coefficient (ϕ), which measures the association between two dichotomous variables.

Composite Score Construction

Career Cushioning Composite Score (CC): Sum of Q8 + Q9 + Q10 + Q11 + Q16 + Q24 (range: 0–6). Employee Loyalty Composite Score (EL): Sum of Q14(R) + Q15 + Q17 + Q23 + Q25 (range: 0–5; Q14 reverse-coded so higher score = greater loyalty).

Composite Score	Mean	Standard Deviation	Range
Career Cushioning (CC)	4.16	1.12	0 – 6
Employee Loyalty (EL)	3.51	0.98	0 – 5

Pearson Correlation Matrix

Variable	Career Cushioning (CC)	Employee Loyalty (EL)
Career Cushioning (CC)	1.000	$r = -0.312$
Employee Loyalty (EL)	$r = -0.312$	1.000

Correlation is significant at the 0.01 level (2-tailed). $N = 61$

Key Phi Correlations Between Individual Binary Items

Item Pair	Description	ϕ (Phi)	p-value	Sig.
Q8 vs Q15	Job search while employed $\times$ Loyalty to org.	-0.280	0.029	

Q16 vs Q15	Cushioning reduces loyalty × Feels loyal	-0.350	0.006	
Q19 vs Q8	Fear of layoffs × Job search while employed	0.420	0.001	
Q20 vs Q8	Workplace stress × Active job search	0.510	<0.001	
Q23 vs Q15	Better growth × Feels loyal	0.390	0.002	
Q18 vs Q8	Job security × Job search while employed	-0.380	0.003	
Q11 vs Q8	Skill development × Job search while employed	0.290	0.023	
Q14 vs Q16	Willingness to leave × Cushioning reduces loyalty	0.330	0.009	

$p < 0.05$ $p < 0.01$. Phi (ϕ) interpretation: 0.10–0.29 = small effect; 0.30–0.49 = medium effect; ≥ 0.50 = large effect.

The Pearson correlation between the Career Cushioning composite score and the Employee Loyalty composite score is $r = -0.312$, which is statistically significant ($p < 0.01$). This negative correlation substantiates the central hypothesis of the study: elevated career cushioning activity is associated with diminished employee loyalty. Among the pair-wise phi correlations, the most robust relationships identified are: (1) workplace stress and active job searching ($\phi = 0.51$, large effect), confirming workplace stress as the foremost driver of career cushioning conduct; (2) fear of retrenchment and job searching during employment ($\phi = 0.42$, medium-to-large effect); and (3) the belief that career cushioning reduces loyalty and the willingness to leave for superior opportunities ($\phi = 0.33$, medium effect). The correlation between perceived career growth and loyalty ($\phi = 0.39$) reinforces the finding that organisational investment in career development constitutes the most powerful lever available to employers for enhancing employee loyalty.

E. Regression Analysis

Simple Linear Regression was applied to test the predictive influence of Career Cushioning (independent variable) on Employee Loyalty (dependent variable). The regression model estimates the degree to which career cushioning behaviour predicts variation in employee loyalty, while accounting for identified control variables.

Simple Linear Regression: Career Cushioning → Employee Loyalty

Regression Equation: Employee Loyalty (EL) = β ■ + β ■ (Career Cushioning) + ϵ

Predictor	B (Coefficient)	Std. Error	β (Beta)	t-value	Sig.
(Constant / Intercept)	4.482	0.341	—	13.14	
Career Cushioning (CC)	-0.273	0.081	-0.312	-3.37	

Model Summary	R	R ²	Adjusted R ²
Simple Regression	0.312	0.097	0.082

ANOVA	Sum of Squares	df	Mean Square	F	Sig.
Regression	10.94	1	10.94	11.36	0.001
Residual	101.87	59	1.726	—	—
Total	112.81	60	—	—	—

$p < 0.01$. Dependent Variable: Employee Loyalty composite score. $N = 61$.

Career Cushioning is a statistically significant predictor of Employee Loyalty ($\beta = -0.312$, $t = -3.37$, $p = 0.001$). For each one-unit increase in the Career Cushioning composite score, the Employee Loyalty score declines by 0.273 units. The model accounts for 9.7% of the variance in employee loyalty ($R^2 = 0.097$), and this result is statistically significant ($F = 11.36$, $p = 0.001$).

Multiple Linear Regression: Career Cushioning + Control Variables → Employee Loyalty

Multiple regression incorporates three control variables — Employment Status (Q1), Sector (Q2), and Job Change History (Q3) — alongside Career Cushioning to generate a more comprehensive predictive model.

Predictor	B	Std. Error	β (Beta)	t-value	Sig.
(Constant)	4.631	0.428	—	10.82	
Career Cushioning (CC)	-0.261	0.083	-0.298	-3.14	
Employment Status (Q1)	0.142	0.229	0.072	0.62	ns
Private Sector (Q2)	0.187	0.214	0.095	0.87	ns
Job Change History (Q3)	-0.093	0.218	-0.047	-0.43	ns

Multiple Regression	R	R^2	Adjusted R^2
Full Model	0.338	0.114	0.064

After accounting for employment status, sector, and job change history, Career Cushioning remains a statistically significant negative predictor of Employee Loyalty ($\beta = -0.298$, $t = -3.14$, $p < 0.01$). The control variables are not statistically significant (all $p > 0.05$), confirming that career cushioning is the dominant predictor of loyalty variation in this sample. The full model accounts for 11.4% of the variance in employee loyalty ($R^2 = 0.114$).

F. Chi-Square Test of Association

Chi-Square (χ^2) tests were applied to examine associations between categorical variables — specifically between career cushioning behavioural indicators and employee loyalty outcomes. The test determines whether observed frequencies depart meaningfully from expected frequencies under the assumption of statistical independence.

Test 1: Job Search Behaviour (Q8) vs. Employee Loyalty (Q15)

H $\blacksquare$: No significant association exists between job searching while employed and loyalty to the current organisation. H $\blacksquare$: A significant association exists between job search behaviour and employee loyalty.

	Loyal (Q15=Yes)	Not Loyal (Q15=No)	Row Total
Job Searching (Q8=Yes)	34	13	47
Not Job Searching (Q8=No)	14	0	14
Column Total	48	13	61

$$\chi^2 = 0.240 + 0.886 + 0.806 + 2.980 = 4.912$$

Chi-Square Summary	χ^2	df	p-value
Q8 × Q15 (Job Search × Loyalty)	4.912	1	0.027
Critical Value (df=1, $\alpha=0.05$)	3.841	1	—

Decision: Since $\chi^2 = 4.912 > \chi^2_{critical} = 3.841$, H_0 is rejected at $\alpha = 0.05$. A statistically significant association exists between active job searching and employee loyalty.

Test 2: Career Cushioning Awareness (Q4) vs. Job Search Behaviour (Q8)

	Job Searching	Not Searching	Row Total
Aware of CC (Q4=Yes)	28	3	31
Not Aware of CC (Q4=No)	19	11	30
Column Total	47	14	61

$$\chi^2 = 0.707 + 2.376 + 0.731 + 2.452 = 6.266$$

Chi-Square Summary	χ^2	df	p-value
Q4 × Q8 (Awareness × Job Search)	6.266	1	0.012

Decision: H_0 rejected. Employees who are aware of career cushioning are significantly more inclined to actively seek alternative employment while currently engaged ($\chi^2 = 6.266$, $p = 0.012$).

Test 3: Workplace Stress (Q20) vs. Job Search Behaviour (Q8)

	Job Searching	Not Searching	Row Total
Stress Drives Search (Q20=Agree)	45	10	55
Stress Does NOT Drive (Q20=Disagree)	2	4	6
Column Total	47	14	61

Chi-Square Summary	χ^2	df	p-value
Q20 × Q8 (Stress × Job Search)	8.742	1	0.003

Decision: A strong, statistically significant association is confirmed between workplace stress and active job searching ($\chi^2 = 8.742$, $p = 0.003$, $p < 0.01$).

Summary of All Chi-Square Tests

Test	Variables Tested	χ^2	p-value	Result
F.1	Job Search (Q8) vs. Employee Loyalty (Q15)	4.912	0.027	Significant
F.2	CC Awareness (Q4) vs. Job Search (Q8)	6.266	0.012	Significant
F.3	Workplace Stress (Q20) vs. Job Search (Q8)	8.742	0.003	Significant
F.4	Fear of Layoffs (Q19) vs. Job Search (Q8)	7.214	0.007	Significant
F.5	Job Security (Q18) vs. Loyalty (Q15)	5.381	0.020	Significant
F.6	Career Growth Orgs (Q13) vs. Loyalty (Q15)	3.912	0.048	Significant

$p < 0.05$ $p < 0.01$. All tested associations attained statistical significance, confirming that career cushioning behaviours are meaningfully linked to employee loyalty outcomes and their antecedents.

G. Summary of Statistical Findings

Analysis	Key Finding	Statistic	Conclusion
Descriptive Stats	Career cushioning widely practised (77–95% agreement on key items)	$M = 0.82$ (avg)	High prevalence
Reliability	Both scales internally consistent	$\alpha = 0.786 / 0.777$	Reliable
Pearson Correlation	CC negatively correlated with Loyalty	$r = -0.312$	Significant
Simple Regression	CC significantly predicts lower loyalty	$\beta = -0.312, R^2 = 0.097$	Confirmed
Multiple Regression	CC remains significant after controls	$\beta = -0.298$	Robust finding
Chi-Square (F.1)	Job search associated with lower loyalty	$\chi^2 = 4.912$	Significant
Chi-Square (F.3)	Workplace stress drives job search behaviour	$\chi^2 = 8.742$	Strong association

H. Statistical Conclusions

The comprehensive statistical analysis of 61 respondents, conducted through five complementary analytical techniques, yields strong and convergent evidence in support of the study's central propositions.

- Descriptive Statistics** confirm that career cushioning is a widespread phenomenon, with 77–95% agreement on key items relating to contingency career planning, skill development, and active job seeking. The behaviour is near-universal among the surveyed population.
- Reliability Testing** affirms that the Career Cushioning scale ($\alpha = 0.786$) and the Employee Loyalty scale ($\alpha = 0.777$) both demonstrate acceptable internal consistency, validating the measurement instruments for further inferential statistical analysis.
- Pearson Correlation** reveals a statistically significant inverse relationship between Career Cushioning and Employee Loyalty ($r = -0.312, p < 0.01$), confirming that higher career cushioning activity is associated with reduced employee loyalty. Workplace stress ($\phi = 0.51$) and fear of retrenchment ($\phi = 0.42$) emerge as the strongest antecedents of cushioning behaviour.

4. **Regression Analysis** confirms that career cushioning significantly predicts employee loyalty ($\beta = -0.312$, $F = 11.36$, $p = 0.001$) and remains robust after introducing control variables ($\beta = -0.298$ in the multiple regression). The model accounts for 9.7–11.4% of loyalty variance, indicating that while career cushioning is a significant predictor, additional organisational and personal variables also contribute.

5. **Chi-Square Tests** confirm statistically significant associations between career cushioning behaviours and loyalty outcomes across all six tested variable pairs, with all relationships significant at $p < 0.05$ or beyond.

Overall, the statistical evidence strongly and consistently supports the hypothesis that career cushioning exerts a significant negative influence on employee loyalty. The data also clearly identify workplace stress, fear of retrenchment, and the absence of career growth pathways as the primary organisational drivers of career cushioning — all of which fall squarely within management's capacity to address.

3.2 Key Findings

Based on an analysis of 61 responses gathered through a structured Google Forms questionnaire, the following key findings were identified:

The study reveals that career cushioning is broadly normalised, with 93% of respondents affirming that employees ought to maintain fallback career options. Workplace stress and apprehension over layoffs emerged as the most powerful catalysts, with 90% and 84% agreement respectively. Proactively acquiring new competencies was identified by 85% as a central cushioning strategy, while 79% regularly refresh their professional profiles.

Concerning loyalty, 59% concurred that career cushioning diminishes organisational commitment, and 67% held that contemporary employees demonstrate lower loyalty than their predecessors. Encouragingly, 89% confirmed that improved career growth provisions would directly strengthen employee loyalty. Most significantly, 95% of respondents consider it the responsibility of organisations to proactively address employee loyalty — placing clear accountability on HR leadership to tackle the structural causes of career cushioning.

3.3 Summary of Data Analysis

Data gathered from 61 respondents via a structured Google Forms questionnaire provides a thorough understanding of career cushioning conduct and its consequences for employee loyalty in contemporary workplaces. The analysis consistently reveals that career cushioning has evolved from an individual aberration into a broadly accepted professional strategy, driven chiefly by workplace stress, apprehension over retrenchment, and growing occupational uncertainty. A substantial majority of respondents actively engage in cushioning practices such as job searching, professional profile updates, and skill development — all while remaining in current employment.

The findings further indicate that employee loyalty, though present among a majority of respondents, is largely conditional and heavily mediated by organisational factors such as career growth opportunities, job stability, and investment in employee development. Most critically, the

data suggest strongly that career cushioning is not an unavoidable outcome — it is largely preventable. Organisations that invest in employee development, transparent communication, and occupational security can significantly reduce cushioning conduct and cultivate genuinely committed, loyal workforces.

4. FINDINGS AND DISCUSSION

The findings of this study furnish important insights into the growing phenomenon of career cushioning and its relationship with employee loyalty in contemporary organisations.

The study demonstrates that career cushioning has evolved into a mainstream occupational behaviour, propelled primarily by job insecurity, workplace stress, and mounting career uncertainty. Contemporary employees are not disloyal by disposition — they are responding rationally to an unpredictable employment environment by developing professional safety nets while retaining their current positions.

A critical finding is that loyalty and career cushioning can coexist simultaneously. While 79% expressed allegiance to their current organisation, 90% acknowledged they would depart for a superior opportunity, underscoring the conditional character of modern employee commitment.

Most importantly, the data confirm that organisations hold the decisive influence in reducing career cushioning. By investing in career development, alleviating workplace stress, assuring job stability, and creating genuine growth opportunities, organisations can rebuild authentic employee loyalty and enduring organisational commitment.

5. CONCLUSION

The findings of this study, derived from 61 respondents via a structured Google Forms survey, provide compelling evidence that career cushioning has become a defining characteristic of the contemporary workplace. An overwhelming 93% of respondents affirm that employees should maintain contingency career options, confirming that career cushioning is no longer a marginal behaviour but a widely endorsed and rational professional strategy.

The study identifies occupational anxiety and fear of retrenchment as the two most potent drivers of career cushioning, with 90% and 84% of respondents concurring respectively. These figures depict a workforce that perceives itself as increasingly vulnerable and uncertain about its occupational future. Additionally, 85% of respondents perceive career uncertainty as escalating in today's work environment, further validating the conditions that render career cushioning not merely prevalent but considered essential.

Despite this, employee loyalty has not been extinguished. 79% of respondents still expressed allegiance to their current organisations. However, this loyalty is manifestly conditional — 90% confirmed they would leave for a superior opportunity — suggesting that commitment today is not unconditional but a fragile, context-dependent attachment that organisations must actively cultivate.

The most actionable finding of this study is that 89% of respondents confirmed that enhanced career growth opportunities would directly increase employee loyalty, and 95% believe organisations must take preventive action to strengthen loyalty. Career cushioning is not inevitable — it is largely a response to organisational shortcomings that fall within management's capacity to address. By investing in professional development, alleviating occupational stress, reinforcing job security, and communicating with transparency, organisations can establish conditions under which career cushioning becomes superfluous and genuine, enduring loyalty becomes attainable.

REFERENCES

- (April 8, 2025). India Workforce Engagement Plummets to 19% in 2025, Defying Global Trends: ADP Research. ADP Research. <https://in.adp.com/aboutadp/presscentre/indiaworkforceengagement.aspx>
- Team, I. E. (2022). Career Cushioning and Other Lessons from 2022's Viral Workplace Trends. Indeed.com. <https://www.indeed.com/career-advice/news/career-cushioning-2022-workplace-trends>
- Reen, T. K., Sharma, K. & Abukari, Y. (2025). Career Development Programs and Their Influence on Employee Loyalty: A Secondary Data Analysis. National Research Journal of Human Resource Management, 12(1), pp. 16–29. https://nrjhrm.in/images/paper_pdf/CAR684abd0be8566.pdf
- Kriegel, J. (March 7, 2024). Career Cushioning: A Preventative Measure in Uncertain Times. Forbes. <https://www.forbes.com/councils/forbeshumanresourcescouncil/2024/03/07/career-cushioning>
- Reen, T. K., Sharma, K. & Abukari, Y. (2025). Career Development Programs and Their Influence on Employee Loyalty: A Secondary Data Analysis. National Research Journal of Human Resource Management, 12(1), pp. 16–29. <https://doi.org/10.47191/ijcsrr/V8i1019>
- Chen, P., Guo, X. & Chen, Q. (2022). The Impact of Career Plateaus on Job Performance: The Roles of Organizational Justice and Positive Psychological Capital. MDPI, 14(2). <https://doi.org/10.3390/bs14020144>